



**Unexpected twist:** The biggest surprise has been the exclusion of veteran Vandana Katariya from the squad for the Women's Asian Champions Trophy. GETTY IMAGES

former Cricket Association of Bihar secretary, who helped reshape IPL's administrative structure, the state's sporting connections have been limited. This will be the first time Bihar hosts a truly international competition.

That the chosen venue is the ancient city of Rajgir — one of India's most widely-visited tourist sites and part of the famed Buddhist circuit, encompassing the famous Nalanda and Magadh regions — is intriguing. The International Sports Complex has been described as a

forward-looking, one-stop facility aimed at developing the state's sporting talent and infrastructure.

For Indian hockey, which has a glorious men's past but an uncertain women's future, it's uniquely symbolic.

It's also a homecoming of sorts

for Harendra. From being mocked with "now Biharis will also play hockey" in his early days to being in charge of the national women's team as the sport reaches his hometown, the highly respected coach has come a long way, both professionally and personally.



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